

Bureaucratic Polity (1947–1973): Cold War Politics, Technocracy, and Military Rule

CHAPTER THREE

Politics and Government of Thailand

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I Military Electoral Politics and the Emergence of Bureaucratic Polity



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The general election of 15 December 1957 revealed the fragmented nature of Thailand's parliamentary landscape.

The Sahaphum Party, led by Sukit Nimmanheminda and aligned with Field Marshal Sarit Thanarat, secured the largest share of seats with 44.

The Democrat Party followed closely with 39, while smaller parties gained modest representation: the Economist Party with 6, the Liberal Democratic Party with 5, the Seri Manangkasila Party with 4, and one seat each for the Nationalist Party, the Hyde Park Movement Party, and the Independent Party.

Strikingly, 59 independents were also elected, underscoring the weakness of partisan organization and the persistence of personalistic politics.

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As a result, the Sahaphum Party failed to achieve a parliamentary majority. In response, Sarit orchestrated the establishment of the Saha Pracha Thai Party (National Socialist Party) as a vehicle for consolidating disparate MPs, including independents, into a governing coalition.

However, Sarit soon fell ill and sought medical treatment in the United States. Parliamentary majority support therefore coalesced around his trusted associate, Lieutenant General Thanom Kittikachorn, who was appointed Prime Minister.

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Thanom's premiership, however, was beset by difficulties: disunity within the ruling party, tensions between the Cabinet and MPs over budgetary allocations, and a broader inability to assert stable parliamentary control. These tensions culminated in a coup d'état staged by the military leadership on 20 October 1958.

Upon his return from medical treatment, Sarit assumed the premiership and dismantled the fragile parliamentary system. He dissolved all political parties, abrogated the constitution, disbanded the House of Representatives, and declared martial law nationwide.

A provisional charter was promulgated that radically transformed the legislative structure: a unicameral assembly composed entirely of appointed members was created, empowered only to enact legislation and draft a constitution, but stripped of any authority to scrutinize or restrain the Cabinet.

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This coup inaugurated a political order dominated by the bureaucracy, both military and civilian, which scholars have characterized as a “bureaucratic polity.”

It represented the most complete centralization of authority since the 1932 revolution. From this point until the mass student-led uprising of 14 October 1973, political power was monopolized by a narrow clique of military elites—principally Sarit, Thanom, and Field Marshal Praphas Charusathien—who ruled with unchecked authority.

Several factors explain the military elite’s ability to exercise such concentrated power.

First, senior officers of this generation were not directly connected to the 1932 revolution and thus felt little obligation to the ideals of the People’s Party.

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Second, Thailand benefitted from substantial support from global powers, especially the United States, which viewed a strong military regime as a bulwark against the spread of communism in Southeast Asia.

Third, civilian actors—including political parties, politicians, interest groups, the press, and the public—were institutionally weak and systematically suppressed, with freedoms of expression and association tightly curtailed.

For these reasons, while mechanisms of political accession during this period formally included general elections, parliamentary votes within appointed assemblies, and military coups, all operated under the overarching dominance of the armed forces. The military, in alliance with the civilian bureaucracy, served as both the foundation and the instrument of a political order in which representative institutions were hollowed out and subordinated to authoritarian control.

II Paternalistic Politics and the Sarit–Thanom Regimes



Paternalistic Politics and the Sarit–Thanom Regimes

Following the coup of 20 October 1958, the Revolutionary Council promulgated the **Provisional Constitution of the Kingdom of Thailand, B.E. 2502 (1959)** on 28 January 1959. Comprised of only twenty articles, the charter vested the government with sweeping and absolute powers in state administration.

Of particular significance was **Article 17**, which authorized the Prime Minister, with cabinet approval, to issue any orders or take any actions deemed necessary to suppress or prevent threats to the security of the Kingdom or the monarchy, as well as to combat subversion, disorder, or external interference.

The provisional charter also created a Constitution Drafting Assembly of 240 appointed members nominated by the Revolutionary Council and formally appointed by the King. More than seventy percent of these members were active civil servants, police, and military officers, while the remainder were retired officials, businessmen, and trusted professionals closely aligned with the regime.

Field Marshal Sarit Thanarat and his fellow military leaders justified this suspension of parliamentary democracy by arguing that Thailand's political parties were factional, opportunistic, and preoccupied with patronage and personal gain.

Party leaders, they contended, routinely leveraged their parliamentary seats to bargain for cabinet portfolios or illicit benefits, withdrawing support from governments when demands were unmet. Such practices were presented as incompatible with political stability and, crucially, as obstacles to the fight against communism, which by the late 1950s was seen as an existential threat to the Thai state.

In its place, Sarit inaugurated a system later termed “**Paternalistic Politics,**” drawing on the Sukhothai-era idiom of the monarch as a “father ruling his children.” This model emphasized security, order, and development as the central sources of legitimacy.

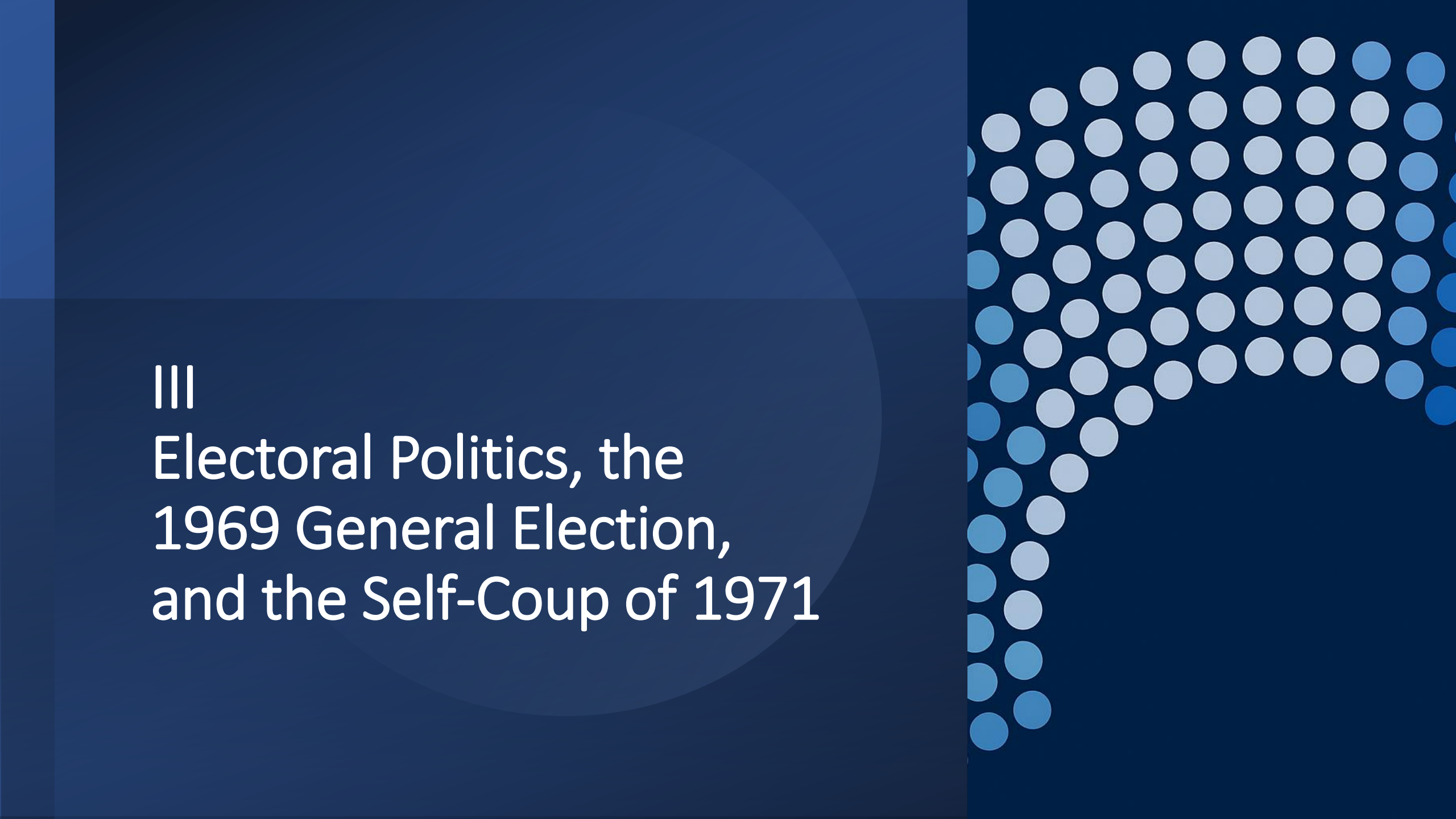
Sarit’s regime articulated its priorities through developmental slogans such as “*flowing water, bright lights, good roads, and jobs for all,*” signaling its focus on material welfare rather than on political rights or liberal freedoms. The paternalistic idiom framed the government as a benevolent guardian whose responsibility was to provide prosperity and stability, while the citizenry’s duty was obedience and loyalty.

However, this paternalistic political order endured for just under five years. On 9 December 1963, Sarit died after 4 years, 9 months, and 28 days in power. He was succeeded immediately by Field Marshal Thanom Kittikachorn, who assumed the premiership the same day.

Thanom, holding both political and military authority, sought to continue Sarit's policies and maintain the structures of paternalistic governance. His cabinet governed under the provisional regime until the promulgation of the Constitution of the Kingdom of Thailand, B.E. 2511 (1968), which formally reintroduced a constitutional framework.

The 1968 Constitution provided the basis for general elections, scheduled for 10 February 1969. In preparation, Thanom founded the United Thai People's Party (Saha Pracha Thai Party) on 24 October 1968, becoming its leader. This was the first political party to be legally registered since Sarit had dissolved all parties in 1958.

The new party primarily absorbed members from earlier pro-military groupings such as the Seri Manangkasila Party, the Sahaphum Party, and the National Socialist Party, serving as the organizational vehicle of the military regime within the constitutional order.



III Electoral Politics, the 1969 General Election, and the Self-Coup of 1971

The general election of 10 February 1969 marked Thailand's first parliamentary contest under the 1968 Constitution.

The results underscored the continuing fragmentation of the party system: the **United Thai People's Party (UTPP)**, led by Field Marshal Thanom Kittikachorn, secured 76 seats; the **Democrat Party** won 57; while smaller parties—including the Economist Front Party (4 seats), the Democratic Front Party (7 seats), the People's Party (2 seats), the Liberal Democratic Party (1 seat), and the Farmer's Party (1 seat)—gained only limited representation.

Strikingly, 71 independents were elected, reflecting the persistent weakness of institutionalized political parties and the dominance of personalistic politics. Of the 219 seats in the House of Representatives, the UTPP emerged as the largest party but fell short of a majority.

Electoral Politics, the 1969 General Election, and the Self-Coup of 1971

To secure parliamentary dominance, Thanom co-opted all 71 independents into his governing coalition, thereby consolidating his position for a third term as Prime Minister. This was notable as the only time he attained the premiership through election by an elected legislature rather than by military or bureaucratic appointment. Yet the coalition government was plagued by chronic conflict.

Contentious debates arose over a bill proposing the broadcast of parliamentary sessions, parliamentary inquiries on foreign policy aimed at forcing the foreign minister's resignation, and most critically, prolonged disputes over the 1972 budget bill. Opposition criticism of budget allocation created a genuine risk of the bill's defeat in the House of Representatives, threatening governmental paralysis.

Amidst these tensions, on 14 November 1971, Thanom and his deputy, Field Marshal Praphas Charusathien, staged a self-coup.

Electoral Politics, the 1969 General Election, and the Self-Coup of 1971

The coup abrogated the 1968 Constitution, dissolved parliament, and reintroduced a provisional charter—the Temporary Charter of the Kingdom of Thailand, B.E. 2515 (1972)—that reinstated an appointed legislature with minimal powers of oversight. This effectively restored the authoritarian framework of Field Marshal Sarit Thanarat's regime, once again concentrating power in the executive under military control.

The 1971 self-coup was less a response to structural deficiencies of the political system than an attempt by Thanom and Praphas to overcome administrative and parliamentary challenges within their own government. Yet in doing so, the regime deepened authoritarian concentration of power and alienated multiple constituencies.

Business elites, students, and segments of the broader public resented the regime's disregard for constitutionalism: Thailand, they noted, had been without a permanent constitution since 1958, and although it had taken a decade to draft the 1968 Constitution, it was annulled after barely three years.

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Corruption scandals within Thanom's government following the coup further eroded its legitimacy.

These conditions culminated in mass mobilization two years later. Student movements, supported by broader segments of society, spearheaded demonstrations demanding democracy and opposing military dictatorship. The protests culminated in the 14 October 1973 uprising, which forced Thanom's resignation and marked the collapse of the bureaucratic polity.

As Kevin Hewison has observed, politics before 1973 remained the preserve of elites, military officers, civil servants, and technocrats, while the people themselves were largely excluded from meaningful participation. Thai politics in this period appeared locked in a vicious cycle of coup, constitutional abrogation, constitution drafting, elections, and renewed coup, reflecting the entrenched dominance of authoritarian and bureaucratic forces.

Electoral Politics, the 1969 General Election, and the Self-Coup of 1971

Recommended Further Readings

- Anderson, Benedict R. O'G. *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism*. Rev. ed. London: Verso, 2006.
- Chaloemtiarana, Thak. *Thailand: The Politics of Despotic Paternalism*. Rev. ed. Ithaca, NY: Cornell Southeast Asia Program Publications, 2007.
- Riggs, Fred W. *Thailand: The Modernization of a Bureaucratic Polity*. Honolulu: East-West Center Press, 1966.
- Hewison, Kevin. "Introduction: Power, Oppositions and Democratisation." In *Political Change in Thailand*, edited by Kevin Hewison, 1–20. London: Routledge.